SEMPLICE ITALIAN KITCHEN | REGIONAL ITALIAN RECIPES

Authentic Focaccia Barese with Boiled Potatoes, Cherry Tomatoes & Olives

PREP: 25 mins | COOK: 25 mins | TOTAL: 50 mins (+ rise) | SERVINGS: 8 generous slices | CALORIES: 365 kcal

INGREDIENTS

* 300g (2.5 cups) Italian 00 Flour or Unbleached Bread Flour
* 200g (1.25 cups) Semola Rimacinata (Finely Milled Durum Semolina)
* 150g (1 medium) Boiled Yellow Potato (peeled and finely riced or grated while warm)
* 360ml (1.5 cups) Lukewarm Water (72% hydration)
* 7g (1 packet / 2.25 tsp) Instant Dry Yeast (plus 1 tsp honey or sugar)
* 12g (2 tsp) Fine Sea Salt
* 60ml (1/4 cup) Extra-Virgin Olive Oil (2 tbsp in dough + 2 tbsp for the baking pan + drizzle on top)
* 250g (15-18) Sweet Cherry Tomatoes (hand-crushed in half)
* 12-15 Bari, Gaeta, or Kalamata Olives
* 1.5 tsp Dried Pugliese Oregano & Coarse Sea Salt (for topping)

STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1: Mix Flour, Semolina & Riced Potato (8 mins)

In a large bowl, whisk together the 00 flour, semola rimacinata, and instant yeast. Rub the warm riced potato into the flour with your fingertips until evenly distributed. Pour in the lukewarm water and honey, mixing with a spoon until a shaggy dough forms, then work in the 12g sea salt and 2 tablespoons of olive oil.

Step 2: Stretch, Fold & Bulk Rise (15 mins)

Perform two sets of stretch-and-folds directly in the bowl spaced 15 minutes apart until the dough is smooth and elastic. Cover tightly and let rise in a warm spot for 90 minutes until doubled and bubbly.

Step 3: Coat the Pan in Olive Oil & Stretch the Dough (15 mins)

Pour 2 generous tablespoons of extra-virgin olive oil into the bottom of a 12-inch round cast-iron skillet or dark metal baking pan. Turn the risen dough into the oil, flip once to coat both sides, let rest 15 minutes, then gently stretch with oiled fingertips to reach the edges.

Step 4: Hand-Crush Cherry Tomatoes & Dimple (30 mins)

Take each cherry tomato, squeeze it gently in half over the dough so the sweet juices drip onto the surface, and press the halves skin-side up deep into the dough along with the black olives. Let proof uncovered for 30 minutes while preheating your oven to 450F (230C) with a rack on the lowest position.

Step 5: Bake on the Bottom Rack for a Crispy Crust (25 mins)

Sprinkle generously with dried oregano, coarse sea salt, and an extra thread of olive oil and 1 tablespoon of water emulsified together. Bake on the bottom oven rack at 450F (230C) for 22-25 minutes until the bottom crust is deeply golden-fried and the top edges are blistered.

NONNA'S CHEF TIPS:

- Squeezing each cherry tomato over the dough and pressing it skin-side up prevents the delicate tomato skins from burning while caramelizing the juices into the bread.
- Baking on the lowest oven rack in a dark metal or cast-iron pan mimics the intense deck heat of a traditional Bari wood-fired oven.